

Episode 102

"How to Befriend a Phantom"

Written by

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Based on

"The Haunting of Dylan Klaypool: Whispers in Black Willow"

by James A. Ross

EXT. GRAVEYARD - NIGHT

Sewn in Autumn ivy, an EPITAPH catches light from the harvest moon and says: "we know what we are, but not what we may be."

MITCH VERLICE (17) sits criss-cross applesauce, petting a STUFFED BLACK CAT like the evil villain in a cartoon.

MITCH
We've been waiting quite a while
for you to bury this body, Dylan
Klaypool.

Wide-eyed as ever with SHOVEL in hand, DYLAN KLAYPOOL (16) turns to Mitch. She addresses the cat.

DYLAN
He's bad luck.

MITCH
Elpis is a she, first and foremost.
OK?

DYLAN
OK, she's bad luck.

MITCH
She doesn't really appreciate all
these critical assumptions you're
making about her character.

DYLAN
She said all that?

MITCH
Yes!

His eyes narrow.

MITCH
...Are you very superstitious?

DYLAN

Yes.

Mitch nods thoughtfully. He jumps up, tossing Elpis, and breaks into a sprint towards his HOUSE.

DYLAN

MITCH! Where are you going?!

Night comes onto Dylan like an unwanted lover. A CAW calls her attention skyward, where focus shifts to HELL HOUSE.

In one of the windows, Dylan catches sight of a shadowy figure. Watching, motionless. She freezes.

DYLAN

Mitch... Mitch!

The wind picks up and Dylan BOLTS. Whirling around to find only shadows in her trail, she charges right into MITCH.

MITCH

Hey. Missed me already?

DYLAN

How dare you?! How dare you leave me out here alone? Like! We're not all you, OK? We don't all just hang out at graveyards in the middle of the night and bury bodies. OK? What do you think? Do you think I even have the muscular strength to dig a six foot hole? Well, I don't. OK? I'm just a little girl. I'm just... going to find another way to prove ghosts exist.

Mitch grabs her hand. He holds up INCENSE, eyes soft.

MITCH

Please stay. I was getting you incense that'll ward off evil.

DYLAN
...You could've just said that.

MITCH
That wouldn't have been very
obscure and alluring of me. So.

DYLAN
(pouty)
I still don't have much muscle.

Mitch stares down at her until she rolls her eyes and
returns to the dig site.

DYLAN
You know what I think is alluring?
The antithesis of obscure. Things
like daylight, safety, warmth.

MITCH
Ah, don't feel bad. Everyone's a
little weird somehow.

As they walk away, fog engulfs the space.

TITLE CARD: EPISODE 2, HOW TO BEFRIEND A PHANTOM.

INT. GRAVEYARD - NIGHT (MOMENTS LATER)

A match illuminates Mitch's eyes. He lights the incense.

MITCH
Espanta muerto.

DYLAN
You're idea of accommodating my
fears is lighting something that
translates to dead scary?

MITCH
Lost in translation. Lesson one!

DYLAN

OK.

MITCH

You've gotta know you don't know
everything and never will.

DYLAN

I know.

Mitch waits for Dylan to hear her echo. She shifts.

MITCH

Espanta muerto better translates to
scaring the dead. In English, they
call it the ghost chaser.

He begins gently coating Dylan in incense.

DYLAN

Why chase away your only friends?

MITCH

You're still here.

DYLAN

We're not friends.

MITCH

Lovers then.

Dylan shakes her head, patience thinning.

MITCH

Also! Not every spirit is friendly.
Which I'm sure is why you've feared
them your whole life despite now
trying to prove their existence. An
endeavor, I may add, motivated by
some mystery I won't even begin to
inquire about, yet alas... They're
gone now. Those unfriendly spirits.
And you're safe.

Something alters in Dylan's eyes. She's safe.

MITCH (V.O.)
Tell me your favorite color.

EXT. GRAVEYARD - NIGHT (MOMENTS LATER)

Dylan is mid-dig, unwavering in her disgust.

DYLAN
Yellow.

MITCH
Oh? Like my nails.

DYLAN
No. Like honeycombs.

MITCH
Choose a season.

DYLAN
Spring.

MITCH
Hm. I thought you hated it when
buried things resurface.

DYLAN
Not daisies.

MITCH
What animal do you think you'd be?
Apart from human, of course.

DYLAN
You'd be a hyena.

MITCH
That could not be more incorrect.

DYLAN
Pretty sure I've got a good handle
on you, but OK.

MITCH
Because you know everything. Right?

DYLAN
Test me.

MITCH
What's my favorite day of the week?

DYLAN
Friday.

MITCH
Monday.

DYLAN
You're such a liar.

MITCH
I never lie.

DYLAN
Then how come no one knows you
dated Carrie?

This one stings. Dylan digs in quiet for a while.

DYLAN
Sorry.

MITCH
What's your birthday?

DYLAN
I don't celebrate it.

MITCH
Don't celebrate your birthday! Why?

DYLAN
I hate Halloween.

MITCH
Shut up. SHUT THE FUCK UP. DYLAN!
Your birthday is HALLOWEEN DAY?!

DYLAN
Is it deep enough?

MITCH
What? My LOVE? Fuck yeah it is.

He smirks, then inspects the hole with a playful superiority.

MITCH
Well, well, well.

He HOPS IN and LAYS DOWN in the dirt.

MITCH
Wanna cuddle?

DYLAN
Bye.

Dylan turns, coming face to face with ABIEZER MARRERO in the silhouette of Frankenstein's monster. She SCREAMS, FALLS, HITS her head on the tombstone, and TUMBLES into Mitch below.

INT. SALEM, 1692, PARRIS RESIDENCE, NURSERY - NIGHT

An EGG CRACKS into a jug of water. Its whites splay in varied directions. A young eye, warped by glass, analyzes.

ABIGAIL (O.S.)
Well, Betty, be not concealed. Do
you see it or not? A ring! I stand
certain of it. Go on. Look.

BETTY PARRIS (9) squints and the egg whites do seem to morph
into a wedding ring. She looks to ABIGAIL WILLIAMS (12).

BETTY
Why, yes, Cousin! I do see! You
shall be happily married indeed.

ANNE PUTNAM (12) enters, followed by DOROTHY GOOD (4) and
VIOLET (4) both laughing. Anne shushes them. They nod.

Anne joins Abigail as a woman washes over Dorothy and
Violet.

TITUBA (O.S.)
Violet?

Violet follows the blue dress up. It's TITUBA (19).

VIOLET
Yes, Mother?

TITUBA
You naughty girl, awake in this
hour. And you've awoken master's
guest, no less. Dorothy, where is
thy mother?

Dorothy ignores Tituba's concern.

DOROTHY
What doth they do, Tituba? With the
eggs.

TITUBA
Find their fortune, Child.

Anne SCREAMS. She goes into hysterics. Tituba runs to her.

ABIGAIL
Anne! What hath taken ahold of you?

VIOLET
Mother! What is the matter?

Dorothy cries. Violet tries comforting her.

ABIGAIL
Dorcas! Would you silence yourself!

Tituba picks up the glass, goes ashen.

BETTY
Well! What is it?

TITUBA
(Ashen)
Nothing, Child.

Streaking down the glasses's interior is a COFFIN.

INT. VERLICE RESIDENCE, MITCH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Dylan's eyes bolt open. JAZZ music plays from some corner in the room. She tries to sit up with urgency, but her hand grabs for the ice pack on her head. Mitch runs in, holding folded clothes and a towel.

MITCH
Woah, Dillstick. Let's slow it down there, yeah?

He helps Dylan sit up.

DYLAN
Where am I?

MITCH
My room.

Dylan looks around, groggy. BOOKS line the walls: gothic, obscure, and occult. INSTRUMENTS of all types are everywhere. The TECHNOLOGY is vintage: cassettes, boom box, DVDs, vinyls. Book and spooky journal pages are taped to the free walls.

DYLAN

No, I'm not. You don't read.

MITCH

Oh. Not nearly enough.

Mitch tosses Dylan the folded clothes and towel, then takes off his shirt. Dylan's eyes shift. Op.

MITCH

For you. To shower.

DYLAN

I'm all right. Thank you.

MITCH

You're covered in grave dirt.

Dylan looks at her clothes and panics, trying to run from it.

INT. VERLICE RESIDENCE, MITCH'S BATHROOM - NIGHT

Dylan, hair wet, wears Mitch's clothes and stares at herself in his mirror. She traces the scar on her forehead, tries to shuffle the bangs to hide it. No avail. SOFT MUSIC comes from behind the door: Mitch playing.

INT. VERLICE RESIDENCE, MITCH'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Mitch is sitting on his bed, playing GUITAR, when Dylan enters. He takes one look over, clocking her scar in a curious way, then smirks. Returns to playing.

Dylan stands, unsure what to do, then heads to the BOOK SHELF. She flips through novels, all fully annotated by

Mitch, and looks at him with furrowed brows.

MITCH

What?

Her eyes narrow. He grins. The exploration continues.

On the floor, she finds a box of things including DRACULA. She reaches for it and Mitch JOLTS.

MITCH

Wait! Not that. It's...

Dylan opens the book without regard for Mitch's pleas.

Inside, she finds a note saying: "To Carrie. I am longing to be with you, and by the sea, where we can talk together freely and build our castles in the air. Love, Mitch."

They look at each other, a silence of understanding. Mitch's facial gestures say, "Yeah. Shit sucked, but whatever."

DYLAN

You have terrible taste.

MITCH

She's actually not really that bad once you get to know her.

DYLAN

I meant in literature.

Mitch puts his guitar aside.

MITCH

Yeah? What's your taste then, huh? Tell me about your favorite books.

DYLAN

I'd be here all night.

MITCH
Sounds nice.

Dylan rolls her head around, both exhausted by his flirting and enjoying it. Her eye catches a creepy illustration over the nightstand: a sexualized woman with a massive scar on her face, standing behind a window.

DYLAN
What in the Wuthering Heights is this?

Mitch grabs it first. He faces away from her.

DYLAN
And right next to your bed. Gosh, Mitch! Gross! Mitch...?

Mitch places the illustration in its original spot with extreme care. He turns toward Dylan, looking down.

MITCH
I apologize if that made you feel uncomfortable. I can see how it could be misleading.

DYLAN
Mitch?

MITCH
Yeah.

DYLAN
Are you OK?

He looks up, TEARY-EYED and SMILING.

MITCH
M-hm.

Mitch goes to the middle of his room and lays on the floor. After a moment, he sits up and gestures for her to join him.

MITCH

Do you remember in the car when I said, you know, all that stuff about the paranormal world meaning nothing is ever really gone?

DYLAN

Yes.

Mitch's smile widens, followed by a tear.

DYLAN

...Do you want to talk about it?

MITCH

Maybe later.

DYLAN

OK. Later.

MITCH

...Were'd you get that scar?

DYLAN

Maybe later.

MITCH

OK. Later.

DYLAN

If it's any consolation, no one believes it more than me. That nothing is ever really gone.

Mitch looks at her long: it is. The intensity dawns on Dylan.

DYLAN

We start tomorrow then?

She begins to go.

MITCH
Oh.

DYLAN
Hm?

MITCH
Nothing.

DYLAN
What?

MITCH
...you could stay.

DYLAN
...would you start teaching me-

MITCH
No. I mean, I could. But...

DYLAN
What?

MITCH
Stay because I want you to.

Dylan THINKS. Her phone RINGS. She picks it up.

DYLAN
(on phone)
Hi, Mom. Yes, everything is going
well. I'm just... with a... friend.
I'll be back before midnight. Bye.

She hangs up. Mitch can't hide his smile.

MITCH
Did you get a concussion or do you
just cave in really fast?

Dylan stares at him with an entirely blank expression.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, KITCHEN - NIGHT

JILL RODRIGUEZ sits, reflecting the call. On her LAPTOP is an article plastered with her smiling face. It reads:
"Voices in the Wind or in Your Head: Dr. Jill Rodriguez Breaks Down the Haunting Symptoms of Schizophrenia."

MIGUEL RODRIGUEZ enters with a box that says "BELONGINGS OF CANDICE GOOD" and a GIFT BASKET OF BREAD. He shakes off the cold.

MIGUEL
How's your book coming along?

JILL
(unfocused)
Still finished.

MIGUEL
You'll never believe what they let me keep from work.

JILL
Did you happen to catch Dylan next door with that blue-haired boy?

MIGUEL
...No, Dear. I try not to make a habit of peeping through windows.

Jill rolls her eyes. She shuts her laptop.

MIGUEL
Want a baguette? It's tasty. A special gift from the chief.

JILL
You see it, right? How much he's... like Dylan's biological father.

Miguel shivers on purpose, sits, munches on his baguette.

JILL
But it's true! Maybe it's... I
don't know. What if it's like...
Some sort of trauma response. Ugh.

Jill puts her hands in her head. Miguel rubs her back.

MIGUEL
All right. OK. Look at me. Hm? Let
me see those eyes.

Jill looks at him.

MIGUEL
Let's switch seats. See the stage
from a different direction. Yeah?
Before we moved to Black Willow,
Dylan couldn't bear to be within a
ten mile radius of anything even a
little related to death. Remember?

JILL
Yes.

MIGUEL
Yeah. So let's give this some time.
See how it plays out. Her bravery
is building and if this boy has
something to do with it, we've
gotta give them some breathing
room. OK?

JILL
OK.

MIGUEL
You're gonna be cool?

JILL
I'm gonna be cool.

MIGUEL
OK. Good. Now. You'll never believe
what they let me keep from work.

Miguel raises the box of Candice's items. Jill sits up
straight, gives him a fiery look of interest.

INT. VERLICE RESIDENCE, ATRIUM - NIGHT

The far off SQUEAL of a kettle reaching it's boiling point
sounds from the kitchen. Dylan is sitting on Mitch's living
room couch, under a Halloween blanket. She clocks Mitch's
shoes: CROCS.

DYLAN
How tragic.

She hears Mitch drop a bunch of things.

MITCH (O.S.)
Oh shit. Fuckidy fuck.

Then-

MITCH (O.S.)
(calling out)
Ghosts or pumpkins?

DYLAN
What?

Mitch walks in carrying two ghost mugs. He hands her one.

DYLAN
Did you put any drugs in it?

MITCH
Just chamomile and a touch of LSD.

She does not waver. He smiles.

MITCH
Just chamomile.

Dylan takes the mug as Mitch takes a seat.

DYLAN
My dad used to make this when I
couldn't sleep.

MITCH
Did it work?

DYLAN
No. It takes melatonin in an IV.

Mitch looks at her, questions all over his face.

DYLAN
Oh. I don't sleep.

MITCH
What? You just don't sleep?

DYLAN
No, I do sometimes, for like half
the night.

MITCH
What do you do...?

She hesitates, apprehensive.

DYLAN
I go to sleep in the afternoon...

MITCH
And then wake up at night to hunt
for virgin blood or what?

Spoken simultaneously.

DYLAN
Ohhhkay.

MITCH
Tell me!

DYLAN
I wake up around 3am- always. Then
I just read. Write. Pray.

MITCH
It's 10pm now.

DYLAN
It's OK.

MITCH
Oh. What? Because I'm worth it?

DYLAN
All right. Relax.

MITCH
It is. You totally think I'm worth
it. Look at you! You're obsessed.

DYLAN
That is not it at all actually. So.
I'm sorry to break it to you.

Dylan sips, looking in his eyes as he makes analyzations.

DYLAN
What?

MITCH
You're weird.

DYLAN
I'm weird? Me?

MITCH

Yes. Yeah, Dylan. You're weird. Why the hell are you trying so hard to prove ghosts exist if you don't even want them to?

DYLAN

I thought you wouldn't dare inquire about this.

MITCH

Well now that was before your mind altering concussion, wasn't it now? ...Why are we doing this?

DYLAN

...my dad ...No. Mitch. I don't want to talk about it. OK?

MITCH

Dylan. It's OK. It's absolutely fine. I don't need to know.

Dylan exhales her gratitude. A beat.

MITCH

But I do need to show you this movie.

Behind a frost-covered window, Mitch hops up and heads to a shelf of VHS tapes. Dylan playfully objects from the couch.

EXT. PSYCH HOSPITAL FOR THE CRIMINALLY INSANE - NIGHT

The back of a TRUCK, parked in an alley. Labeled: CHICAGO FOOD SUPPLY CO. The DRIVER emerges, lifts the trunk. The boxes are labeled "PERISHABLE."

A NURSE opens the alley door, eying their surroundings.

DRIVER

I got an order for the Chicago psychiatric hospital. Says you got
(MORE)

DRIVER (CONT'D)
an order of beans.

He hands the nurse a paper to sign.

NURSE
That's right. Beans.

The driver almost grins, pulling back with the signature. When he turns to shut the trunk, a tattoo on the whole of his buzzed head reads "BS."

INT. PSYCH HOSPITAL, LAB - NIGHT

The psych ward lab is alive as though it were mid-day. The NURSE opens the door, allowing a wave of patient's SCREAMS to enter the room. She pushes a cart of cans labeled "BEANS," heading towards a working CHEMIST.

NURSE
Sir. It's the codeine.

He gives her a look: hello?! SHUSH.

CHEMIST
Thank goodness.

He opens a can and pulls out codeine from inside of it. His WALKIE TALKIE crackles and a NURSE 2 speaks from it.

NURSE 2 (O.S.)
Sir, we're desperate. Room 333.

CHEMIST
Is that the one who came as a
circus clown or the ghost guy?

NURSE (O.S.)
Ghost guy. He won't stop talking
about his daughter.

A man's scream echos before the line cuts. The chemist purses his lips, disappointed, and heads towards a cabinet. He opens it, revealing cans labeled "gasoline," "paint thinner," "hydrochloric acid," and "red phosphorus." He gets to work.

NURSE

It's killing them. The Krokodil,
Sir. I mean, they're still human.

The chemist looks at a whiteboard of patient images, focusing in on a photo of NATHAN KLAYPOOL. He sighs.

CHEMIST

They're killing themselves.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, LIVING ROOM - DAWN

Jill sits in the living room, sleepless, as dawn approaches. Rummaging through Cuppa's old things with mixed distain and nostalgia, she does a double take at the window. YAWNS.

JILL

I've gotta go to sleep.

A bone SMASHES onto Dylan's bedroom window. Jill JUMPS.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, DYLAN'S BEDROOM - DAWN (CONTINUOUS)

Dylan JOLTS awake, bones flying at her bedroom window.

MITCH

RISE AND SHINE, MAGGOT. TRAINING
BEGINS. RIGHT NOW. LET'S GO. NO
TIME TO WASTE. ONE TWO THREE FOUR
TWO, TWO THREE FOUR SIX, SIX, SIX
ELEVEN, ELEVEN, FOUR, TWENTY.

Dylan checks her clock: 5:45AM. She opens the window and a bone flies into her room.

DYLAN
What IS that?!

MITCH
A fibula. Hurry up! I'm hungry!

INT. HALL RESIDENCE, SAWYER'S BATHROOM - DAY

1960s music. A hand swipes across the foggy mirror, revealing SAWYER HALL. Towel wrapped around the waist, he stares at himself like a stranger. Combs his hair in an odd way, winks at himself with finger guns. That was stupid.

PARKER HALL enters, holding a PROTEIN SHAKE.

PARKER
Hey.

SAWYER
Sup. Hey.

PARKER
There's a party at Dakota's next Friday. Her birthday or something.

Parker brushes his teeth as Sawyer nods anxiously.

SAWYER
Cool. What are you gonna get her?

PARKER
Nothing. What the fuck do I look like? La Befana? And you shouldn't get her anything either or she'll think you're obsessed.

Sawyer walks out of the bathroom and into...

INT. HALL RESIDENCE, SAWYER'S BEDROOM - DAY (CONTINUOUS)

Sawyer jumps over his guitar on the floor, a Stupid Ball Pit Cult audition flyer beside it. He puts on clothes, tucks in his shirt and tightens the collar. Parker enters with his shake.

PARKER
Loosen the tie.

Sawyer rolls his eyes, but loosens the tie. He grabs his skateboard and backpack.

PARKER
You'll cover me for being late,
right?

SAWYER
Right.

Sawyer leaves. Parker spills the shake all over his face trying to pour more out. Dang.

INT. BLACK WILLOW ACADEMY PARKING LOT, MITCH'S CAR - DAY

Mitch parks. He pulls out a drippy breakfast pizza and gets to gobbling it. Dylan makes no effort at hiding her disgust.

MITCH
I wrote a syllabus.

He nods to a spooky sticker coated folder on the dashboard.

DYLAN
It's been six hours.

MITCH
What? You think you're the only
vampiric, straight A student in
this car? Pass the quad espresso,
please.

She does. He gulps it in one swallow and exhales.

MITCH
Refreshing.

Dylan stares, appalled.

MITCH
Chop chop. Hello? We've only got
thirty minutes to look it over.

EXT. BLACK WILLOW ACADEMY - DAY

As early STUDENTS pile into school, a GARDENER hand shears a round HEDGE. Behind him, one student startles another. The second student SCREAMS, causing the gardener to CHOP a huge hole into the bush. He looks around to see if anyone noticed.

EXT. BLACK WILLOW ACADEMY, PARKING LOT - DAY

Carrie sits on the hood of a pink Volkswagen beetle, lighting a joint with a pink lighter that says the word "BITCH" in cheap, fuchsia rhinestones.

She observes Dylan and Mitch emerge from his car. She locks eyes with Mitch and he averts his gaze, turning his energy inward.

DYLAN
Ok, I need to go a little ahead.
See you after school.

MITCH
Why? So you're not seen with me?

DYLAN
No? What kind of screwed up people
go to this school to even care
about that? Gosh, I have to pee. Is
that all right with you?

Mitch bows to let her go. He walks the opposite way, avoiding Carrie's eye.

CARRIE
She's cute.

He ignores her. Carrie offers the joint.

CARRIE
Want some? For old time's sake?

Mitch walks to her.

MITCH
What are you doing?

CARRIE
Um. Being fucking friendly and
mature. Ever tried it?

Mitch rolls his eyes, starts to take a hit.

CARRIE
You know who really taught me that?
Parker.

Mitch exhales, then CHUCKS the unfinished joint into the
forest.

CARRIE
Wow really, Mitch?

He walks away, Carrie calling after him.

CARRIE
What would Dylan say, huh?! She
could've used that stuff, you know?
Kid can't even play Ouija board
without fainting for fuck's sake.

Mitch puts his headphones in, MUSIC starting.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, SILO FIRST FLOOR - DAY

Dylan opens the armoire that leads to the attic.

DYLAN
Here's where I keep the ghost
hunting equipment.

Mitch looks around the closet, seeing nothing.

MITCH
I'm not sure how to tell you this.

Dylan walks into the armoire, disappearing.

MITCH
...WHAT?

BEGIN MONTAGE:

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, SILO ATTIC - DAY

MITCH (V.O.)
OK. There are two types of
hauntings. Residual and
intelligent.

Mitch whips around, blackboard behind him. He holds a
pointer made to look like a broom stick.

MITCH
I'm looking for something
intelligent.

Dylan sits at the table, an array of study supplies at her
disposal. Everything organized. She grins, in her element.

DYLAN
Look no further.

EXT. WOODS - DAY

Dylan sits under a tree, taking notes as Mitch paces.

MITCH (V.O.)
If you think this will come easy,
just because you know how to study,
you're wrong. All your fears will
be challenged. You will be tested
not only mentally, but spiritually.
Sometimes even physically.

Mitch pulls out a MEL-METER and extends the antenna.

MITCH
Touch this for me real quick.

Dylan touches it. A siren blares. Startled, she hits her head on a branch.

CUT TO:

EXT. WOODS - DAY (MOMENTS LATER)

Dylan sits in the same spot, ice pack on her head.

MITCH
This is a mel-meter. It measures
Electromagnetic Fields from thirty
hertz all the way to three-hundred
hurtz. If it goes off untouched,
you've got a ghost.

Dylan glares and he grins.

MITCH
Approach with caution.

INT. VERLICE RESIDENCE, MITCH'S BEDROOM - DAY

Dylan follows Mitch as he scans his books on the occult, a pile already in hand as he loads her with more.

DYLAN
You hear them through EMFs?

MITCH
Nah. EVPs. And you've gotta be able to say the word spirits or I'm gonna fail you.

He hands her, "History of Hauntings: Salem, Massachusetts."

DYLAN
Absolutely not. I'm not reading that.

MITCH
Dylan, this is so essential it's not even funny.

DYLAN
Mitch. I will never sleep again if I read that.

MITCH
Good. It'll give you lots of time to study up.

He walks away, leaving Dylan deflated.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, DYLAN'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Dylan sits at her desk, reading the history of hauntings with a terrified expression. She has coffee nearby, lights bright. Outside of her window is a beaming crescent moon.

She senses her curtains move and hesitantly looks in that direction, clutching her necklace.

JILL (V.O.)
Dylan?

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, KITCHEN - DAY

Dylan jumps up, startled, with oatmeal on her face.

DYLAN
What is it?!

JILL
You fell asleep in your oatmeal
again.

Jill hands her a napkin.

MITCH (V.O.)
The history of the Jack O' Lantern
starts with Stingy Jack, a drunk
who tricked the devil twice.

EXT. MARY'S BATH - DAY

Dylan and Mitch carve pumpkins on a picnic blanket. Dylan is
a mess, unskilled and grossed out by all the pumpkin guts.

DYLAN
Into doing what?

MITCH
Not taking his soul. But Heaven
wouldn't take it either and he was
left to roam the Earth with a
turnip lit by hellfire.

DYLAN
Oh.

MITCH
So now we do this to rid off Stingy
Jack and any other evil spirits.

DYLAN
If Jack wasn't afraid of the devil,
how is this supposed to scare him?

She spins her pumpkin, showing the face. It's adorable.

MITCH
Oh, you don't know?

DYLAN
...no?

MITCH
Like this.

Mitch throws pumpkin guts at Dylan. It evolves into a full on food fight. He picks her up and spins her around. She laughs.

EXT. MARY'S BATH - DAY (MOMENTS LATER)

Dylan and Mitch sit side by side, covered in pumpkin guts, looking out at a lake near Hell House.

MITCH
That's Mary's bath. The lake.

DYLAN
Why is it called Mary's bath?

MITCH
It was once considered holy. So women would go there long ago. 1700s or so. Trying to abort their babies in the hopes they'd still make it to Heaven.

DYLAN
How would that even work?

MITCH
They'd go with them.

Mitch looks out onto the lake as Dylan looks at him.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, DYLAN'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Dylan sits on her bed with wet hair, surrounded by journals covered in spooky illustrations. She finishes the book on Salem hauntings and closes it, grabbing her necklace.

She receives a calendar notification that says, "Meeting with Dad at 6pm tomorrow." She YAWNS.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, DYLAN'S BEDROOM - NIGHT (MOMENTS LATER)

Dylan places the cute pumpkin on her nightstand and lights it from within. She puts sage inside and the incense pours out.

Dylan goes to sleep beside a clock that says 10pm.

END MONTAGE.

INT. BLACK CAT COFFEE SHOP, COUNTER - DAY

Black Cat Coffee Shop is small. Virtually empty. VEDA WARCLOUD stands behind the counter.

VEDA
I reserve the right to refuse
business to anyone I'd like.

DYLAN
Veda. Give me the chai latte.

VEDA
Give me back my best friend.

DYLAN
OK. Mitch!

Mitch looks over from his table.

DYLAN
Looks like we gotta call it quits
or I'll never get a chai latte in
this town.

She gives Veda a look and walks towards their table as Mitch approaches the counter.

Sawyer emerges from the back, near the books. He's holding a collection of work by Oscar Wilde.

DYLAN
Sawyer!

MITCH
(To Veda, at
counter)
I'll let you dance on one of the
graves.

Something sparks in Veda's eyes.

MITCH
Only contemporary.

VEDA
Tap dance.

MITCH
Absolutely not.

They stare each other down until Veda begins brewing. Mitch goes to the table.

MITCH
Let's hope spit is in season.

SAWYER
Oh. You. You're in that band right?
You guys are having auditions.

MITCH

Yes sir. Tomorrow morning. You trying out?

SAWYER

Ah I don't think so. Tonight's Dakota's party and-

MITCH

Party?

SAWYER

Yeah. It's like, it's a whole thing. My brother and Carrie are going in vintage Chanel, I hear.

Mitch stiffens. Dylan meets his eye and comfort washes over.

SAWYER

You guys wanna come?

DYLAN

Oh, I don't...

MITCH

Yes.

Dylan, horrified, exchanges a look with enthusiastic Mitch.

MITCH

Dylan loves to party. She won't shut up about wanting to party. Really, it's rather tiresome but what's a boy to do. Am I right?

Dylan gives him an awful look.

MITCH

Well, see you there. Toodles 'till then. Stay real.

SAWYER
Oh. Yeah, cool. Um. Toodles.

He gives Mitch an awkward fist bump that Mitch turns into an extensive handshake, then gives Dylan an extra wave.

MITCH
Great taste by the way. Big Wilde fan.

Sawyer blushes, leaving. Mitch turns back to Dylan.

MITCH
I think he's into you.

Dylan glares at him as he grins.

INT. HALL RESIDENCE, SAWYER'S BEDROOM - DUSK

The Hall twins sit in Sawyer's room, drinking beer.

PARKER
Do I look fucking stupid in this vintage Chanel?

SAWYER
No, Bro. It's really cool. Like groundbreaking kind of.

Parker sees Dakota's wrapped gift peaking out from under the bed, not knowing what it is.

PARKER
What'd you buy?

SAWYER
(panicked)
What? Nothing. It's nothing.

Parker nods. Silence. More sips.

SAWYER
Where's dad?

PARKER
Out cold.

SAWYER
Mom?

PARKER
I don't know. Doing mayor stuff.

Sawyer nods.

SAWYER
I think I'm gonna do it. You know.
I know you said not to, but it'll
be good I think. I don't know. It's
cool...

PARKER
What are you even talking about?

SAWYER
Auditioning. For that band.

PARKER
What? That Lame Balls Cult band?

SAWYER
Stupid Ball Pit Cult.

PARKER
Bro! Like I care.

SAWYER
Then you won't mind if I'm in it.
All right? I'm doing it. So.

PARKER
Play for me.

Sawyer freezes.

PARKER

I've never even seen you play.
You're gonna audition? Play for me.

SAWYER

Right now? I... I don't know. I'm
like a little drunk. I-

Parker pats him on the shoulder, gives him an extended look.
Then he gets up, leaving Sawyer.

INT. BLACK WILLOW ACADEMY, LIBRARY - NIGHT

Dylan and Mitch sit at a dimly lit table littered with
notebooks and flashcards. One other STUDENT studies far
behind them.

MITCH

Do you think I should wear my
spider studs or my spider dangles
tonight?

DYLAN

I think you should read the next
question.

Mitch jokingly rolls his eyes, flips to the next flashcard.
At some point, the other student leaves.

MITCH

Ingredients in a house cleaning
smudge stick.

DYLAN

White sage, sweetgrass, and cedar.

MITCH

Rocks that amp up paranormal
activity.

DYLAN
Quartz and sandstone.

MITCH
Last one. You see a ghost. An
intelligent haunting. What do you
do?

DYLAN
Treat it like a normal human being.

MITCH
...You're ready.

DYLAN
For Hell House?

Mitch laughs his loud laugh.

MITCH
Nah. For this.

He plops a huge stack of papers in front of Dylan.

DYLAN
You have to be kidding.

MITCH
Nope. Nothing under an A plus.

Mitch starts packing up.

DYLAN
Where are you going?

MITCH
What do you think? I've gotta get
going if I'm gonna be the hottest,
most esoteric boy at this party.

DYLAN

But...

A light flickers and Dylan tenses.

MITCH

Is little miss Dillstick scared of
a little old empty library?

She pouts. Mitch meets her at eye level.

MITCH

But you've been practicing for
this. Right? How is a spirit able
to materialize?

DYLAN

By feeding off the energy of who's
witnessing it.

MITCH

Correct. So deep breaths, OK? You
have as much control over them as
you have over yourself.

Dylan nods, builds up her courage.

DYLAN

OK. I can do it. I'll meet you at
the party once I finish the test.

Mitch smiles and turns to go before reconsidering.

MITCH

Dillstick? Thanks.

DYLAN

For what?

MITCH

Being seen as much as you see.

Dylan responds with a curious smile. Mitch nods, leaves. The library darkens without him. The images on her notebook become more ominous. Lights flicker.

Her phone buzzes: "Meeting with Dad: 5 min."

A faint thump echoes.

DYLAN
Hello?

She grips her necklace. The sound grows louder--a BANG. Dylan stands, knocking over her chair. A pile of books lies on the floor. Every title is about Salem.

SHADOW MAN (V.O.)
Child.

Dylan stumbles back, clutching her necklace tighter.

DYLAN
No no no.

Dylan searches her bag for incense and a match. She tries desperately to light it, but the flame keeps going out.

At the far end of the library, a single light goes on and off. A FIGURE appears.

DYLAN
GO AWAY!

A gust of wind, then every light turns on at once.

INT. GARDNER RESIDENCE, LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Your classic small town high school party. Mitch walks into the swarm. He sees Sawyer, who flags him down. It's loud.

SAWYER
Hi.

MITCH
What?

SAWYER
I said hi? Like hey.

MITCH
Sorry. What'd you say?

SAWYER
Oh. Nothing. I just said-

Mitch gets a call from Dylan. He holds the phone up for Sawyer, who looks a little upset about it.

MITCH
Is there a room where I can take this?

SAWYER
Upstairs?

Mitch pats him on the shoulder, heads upstairs.

INT. GARDNER RESIDENCE, UPSTAIRS HALLWAY - NIGHT

Mitch weaves through a crowded hallway. He tries a door. Locked. He tries another.

Inside: Carrie and Parker. In bed.

Mitch and Carrie lock eyes. The moment stretches, heavy.

PARKER
Hello, Bro. What the fuck?

Mitch is clearly about to cry. He ducks out.

INT. GARDNER RESIDENCE, UPSTAIRS HALLWAY - NIGHT

Mitch finds a corner to hide in, trying to steady his breath. His phone lights up: DYLAN. He hesitates before swiping to pick up.

MITCH
Hello?

DYLAN (O.C.)
It didn't work!

MITCH
What? What didn't work?

EXT. BLACK WILLOW ACADEMY - NIGHT

Dylan paces, hyperventilating. Beside her is the hedge from before, now reshaped into a JACK'O LANTERN.

INTERCUT PHONE CALL with Black Willow Academy and Corner.

DYLAN
Where are you?

MITCH
The party. But Dylan, You don't have to come here anymore. I don't-

DYLAN
No. I want to go. I need to be just totally surrounded by people.

MITCH
OK, but-

The line cuts off. Dylan has hung up. Mitch goes manic.

MITCH
I'm gonna get fucking wasted.

INT. GARDNER RESIDENCE, LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Mitch gets fucking wasted, downing shots in a strobe light.

EXT. GARDNER RESIDENCE, FRONT YARD - NIGHT

The party is in full swing, it's FUN. LEXIE WILSON sits on the the front porch next to MIA BENNETT, both drinking. Mia is laughing uncontrollably.

LEXIE
OK, Mia! Stop! It's literally a
disaster. Like, let's be real.

Mia calms as Lexie tries to hit her vape.

MIA
I'm sorry. You're right. It's
really not that bad.

They burst into laughter, falling over each other as Dylan approaches in a panic. Lexie nudges Mia. Dylan spots them.

DYLAN
Hi. Have either of you seen Mitch?

MIA
Are you OK?

DYLAN
I just really need to see Mitch
right now.

Lexie drunkenly whispers to Mia so that Dylan can hear.

LEXIE
I'm forbidden from helping her.

Mia rolls her eyes and addresses Dylan.

MIA
(Very much so)
We've seen him.

Dylan's eyes go wide. What has he done?

INT. GARDNER RESIDENCE, LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Mitch is performing like Half Time at the Super Bowl depends on it. Karaoke. Everyone inside is watching him, cheering. Dylan's jaw drops.

MITCH
Thank you, everybody! Kisses!
Besos! And don't forget that my
band Stupid Ball Pit Cult is
holding auditions for a new member
bright and early tomorrow. Eleven
AM. Crack of dawn basically.

Mitch sees Dylan.

MITCH
HOLY SHIT, DILLSTICK! AH! YOU'RE
HERE. Dillstick, come here. Come up
here. You're so pretty. You're so
pretty in such an arcane kind of
way. Have I ever told you that? And
that's like my favorite kind of
way. So... Come up! Everyone needs
to see it.

Dylan looks around self consciously. Mitch wobbles back.

MITCH
No? I mean... I mean, why's that?
Are you, like, embarrassed? Are you
like embarrassed to be seen with me
or some shit? Because that would
be... I mean, well that would just-

He looks around at everyone's concerned faces.

MITCH

HEY! While I have your attention...
Did I ever tell you guys that that
girl over there. With the... hair.
You guys know her. Carrie! Black
Willow's resident bitch.

DAKOTA

HEY!

MITCH

Heyyyy. Omg, happy birthday. This
will just take a sec and then we
can chat for sure. OK, Indiana?

Carrie's friends look between each other, unsure how to
handle the situation. Carrie holds Parker back, intrigued.

MITCH

I want to tell of all you that
Carrie and I had sex! Many times!
Because guess what. She was in
love...

The room goes quiet as everyone looks at Carrie.

CARRIE

That's quite the manifestation.

She laughs, everyone follows except for Dylan. Parker walks
up to the stage and Mitch looks down at him.

PARKER

All right, Bro. Time to get the
fuck off this stage before I get
you the fuck off this stage.

Mitch doesn't flinch. Parker reaches for him and Mitch
shoves his hand. Parker pushes him and, before long, a fight
begins. Mitch falls to Dylan's feet. He looks up at her.
Help.

Every eye lands on Dylan. She walks away.

EXT. GARDNER RESIDENCE, FRONT YARD - NIGHT

Dylan bolts out the door, Mitch stumbling after her.

MITCH

What the hell was that?

DYLAN

What was that? Mitch, what the hell is this?!

MITCH

Dylan. Don't be such a puritan.

DYLAN

This isn't just about you being a drunken mess. Why would you say that about Carrie in front of everyone?

MITCH

What? CARRIE? You're defending Carrie? Carrie, who left you alone after fainting? That Carrie? The same Carrie who shattered my whole fucking heart? You know what? Cool! You and your new best friend Carrie can go ride off into the sunset for all I care. Good luck proving ghosts exist with someone who doesn't even have a soul! Oh! And you know what, while I'm at it, aren't you the one who called me a liar for not telling the whole world who I used to fuck? Hm? Well here I am, baby, loud and proud! Honest as a fucking elephant.

DYLAN

...You're exactly like who I thought you were.

MITCH

And you're nothing like who I thought you were.

They stare at each other until Dylan leaves.

Mitch runs to the bushes and throws up. He burrows into the fetal position. Carrie approaches, wakes him with her foot.

MITCH
What do you want? My veins have
already been sucked dry.

CARRIE
I called you a car.

EXT. GARDNER RESIDENCE, FRONT YARD - NIGHT

Sawyer sits on the sidewalk while smoking a joint. The party sounds far off. Dakota joins him, taking a hit herself.

DAKOTA
Sawyer Dawson Hall.

SAWYER
I'm sorry your party got so messy.

DAKOTA
He called me Indiana.

They LAUGH.

DAKOTA
Nah it was like an Oscar Wilde play
or something. I adored it.

Sawyer hides a smile.

SAWYER
I got you a gift.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Dylan bursts into her house, startling Jill.

JILL
Dylan? What's wrong? What happened?

Dylan approaches the fireplace. She pulls out her notes.

JILL
Dylan!

DYLAN
Go away!

JILL
DYLAN.

DYLAN
GO AWAY!

Jill grabs Dylan by both wrists. Dylan breaks free.

DYLAN
You're not someone I feel safe to
express myself with. Please go.

Jill leaves. Dylan claws at her hair and burrows into a ball.

DYLAN (V.O.)
I've thought about it.

INT. CHICAGO KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, KITCHEN - DAY (FLASHBACK)

THREE PUMPKINS sit on a table. YOUNG DYLAN (6) analyzes them with extreme care, not pleased, while Jill fails to hide her impatience.

DYLAN (V.O.)
Abandoning you was cruel after such
effort on your end, but I tend to
cower under pressure.

NATHAN (O.S.)
Dylan! Forget those. I found just
the one.

She lights up at her dad entering the room.

DYLAN (V.O.)
Nonetheless, I think it's best we
let bygones be. Nathan holds out A
TINY, PINK PUMPKIN with HARD SHELLS
all around it. Jill LAUGHS.

YOUNG DYLAN
Ew, Daddy.

NATHAN
But what's wrong with it? Look a
little closer. Go on. A lotta weird
stuff on the outside, right? Yeah,
I know. But can you guess what
that's made of? It's sugar! Crazy,
huh? Just think about that.

He looks up at Jill, making sure she hears this part.

NATHAN
This little pumpkin has so much
extra sweetness that the sugar
hardened into a shield to protect
its mushy insides.

Young Dylan smiles, in awe.

DYLAN (V.O.)
You've already taught me everything
I need to know.

INT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, DYLAN'S BEDROOM - DAY

Dylan sits on the bed, phone in front of her showing the
text to Mitch: "I've thought about it..."

She looks up to a PHOTO of her and the peanut pumpkin.

DYLAN
An ugly shell of excess sugar...

She exhales sharply, then deletes the text.

The faint sound of approaching sirens pierces the quiet. Her head snaps up, heart pounding as the noise grows louder. She approaches her window to see the AMBULANCE pull into Mitch's driveway.

She rushes out.

EXT. KLAYPOOL RESIDENCE, FRONT DOOR - DAY

Dylan opens the door to find Veda pale and visibly shaken.

VEDA
Mitch is gone.

DYLAN
Gone? What do you mean gone?

VEDA
I found his shoes... by the lake.

DYLAN
What lake?

VEDA
...Mary's Bath.

Dylan runs past her, desperate, heading uphill.

EXT. MARY'S BATH - DAY

Mitch's crocs sit abandoned near the shoreline, the scene unnervingly still. Sirens echo through cold air.

Dylan charges in, breaking through the slushing water with frenetic splashes.

DYLAN
MITCH! MITCH!

She's shaking, gasping for breath between paddles, about to lose consciousness.

END OF EPISODE